

Prepared by
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for the
Popcorn
Board

March 10,
2026

FOOD, NUTRITION AND SNACKING TRENDS

WHAT WE'LL EXPLORE TODAY



DIETARY
GUIDELINES



PROTEIN



ULTRAPROCESSED
FOOD



GLP-1
MEDICATIONS



FOCUS ON FIBER



SNACKING TRENDS



UPDATES

NEW
PYRAMID
TURNS
EVERYTHING
UPSIDE
DOWN

DIETARY GUIDELINES FOCUS ON "REAL FOOD"

TOP TAKE-AWAYS

PROTEIN
WHOLE GRAINS
FATS
UPFs
SUGAR
SALT



ENDING “THE WAR” ON PROTEIN

- INCREASED RECOMMENDATIONS TO 1.2 TO 1.6 G PER KG OF BODY WEIGHT PER DAY (PREVIOUS RECOMMENDATION WAS .8 G PER KG)
- RED MEAT POSITIONED AS KEY SOURCE OF PROTEIN



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WHOLE GRAINS FALL TO THE BOTTOM OF THE PYRAMID

- ENCOURAGE WHOLE GRAINS, NOT REFINED
- FOCUS ON FIBER-RICH
- 2-4 SERVINGS PER DAY
- BUT PLACEMENT ON THE BOTTOM OF THE PYRAMID RAISED CONCERN



BUTTER IS BACK

- Although recommendation suggests saturated fat consumption should not exceed 10% daily calories, reports cite full-fat dairy as source of healthy fats.
- Also suggests choosing fats with essential fatty acids, such as olive oil, but says other options can include butter or beef tallow.
- Suggests limiting highly processed foods to meet sat fat recommendation



UPFS VS. REAL FOOD

TRUE FOCUS OF GUIDELINES,
SITE CHANGED TO
REALFOOD.GOV

MIKE TYSON BECOMES FACE OF
REAL FOOD WITH SUPER BOWL
AD

ENCOURAGES CONSUMERS TO
AVOID "HIGHLY PROCESSED,
PACKAGED, PREPARED, RTE OR
FOODS THAT ARE SALTY OR
SWEET

LIMIT FOOD & BEVERAGES WITH
ARTIFICIAL FLAVORS,
PETROLEUM-BASED DYES,
ARTIFICIAL PRESERVATIVES, AND
LOW- AND NO-CALORIE
SWEETENERS



Processed Food Kills

SUGAR BECOMES PRIORITY OVER SALT

No amount of added sugars or non-nutritive sweeteners is recommended or considered part of a healthy or nutritious diet, one meal should contain no more than 10 grams of added sugars

When selecting snack foods, added sugar limits should follow FDA “Healthy” claim limits. For example, grain snacks (e.g., crackers) should not exceed 5 grams of added sugar per $\frac{3}{4}$ ounce whole-grain equivalent, and dairy snacks (e.g., yogurt) should not exceed 2.5 grams of added sugar per $\frac{2}{3}$ cup equivalent.

Refined grains are “sugars in disguise”

Reinforces sodium consumption limits but also suggests consumers add salt at the table



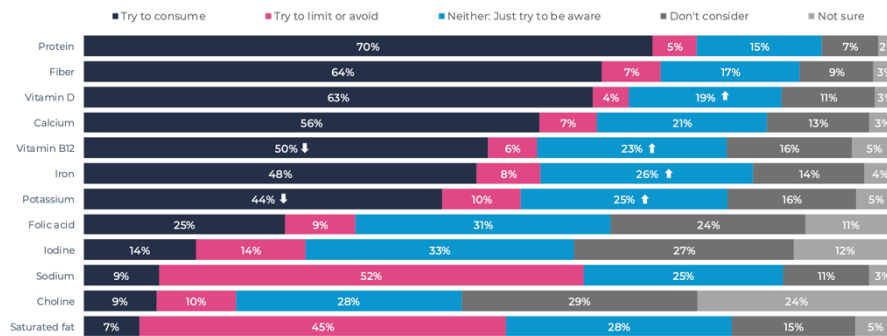
CONSUMERS
CONTINUE
TO DEMAND
PROTEIN

JUMPING ON THE BANDWAGON

Since 2021, protein is the nutrient that most Americans report trying to consume, and sodium is the nutrient most try to limit or avoid.

Compared to 2021, more Americans now try to consume protein (70% vs. 62%), fiber (64% vs. 56%), and vitamin D (63% vs. 56%), and more aim to limit or avoid sodium (52% vs. 47%).

Nutrients Americans are Trying to Consume and Limit/Avoid



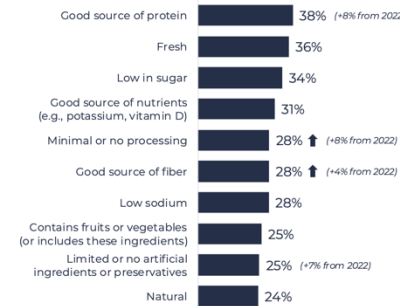
[TREND 2019-2025] N5 Do you generally try to consume or avoid the following? (n=3000)
 Note: These twelve nutrients are selected due to their status in the DGA 2020-2025 as dietary components of public health concern for under- and overconsumption across the lifespan.
 Note: Protein was included in 2021.
 Note: Arrows indicate significance of 2025 vs. 2024.
 Note: Totals may not equal 100% due to rounding.

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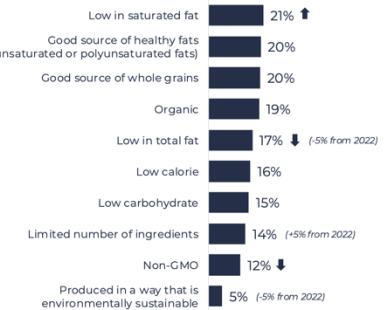
In 2025, “Good source of protein” takes the top spot for criteria used to define a healthy food, followed by “Fresh” and “Low in sugar.” The top three have remained the same since 2022.

Compared to 2024, more Americans use “Minimal or no processing,” “Good source of fiber,” and/or “Low in saturated fat” to define a healthy food. Fewer use “Low in total fat” and/or “Non-GMO.”

Criteria Used to Define a Healthy Food
(Top 10 choices)



Criteria Used to Define a Healthy Food
(Bottom 10 choices)

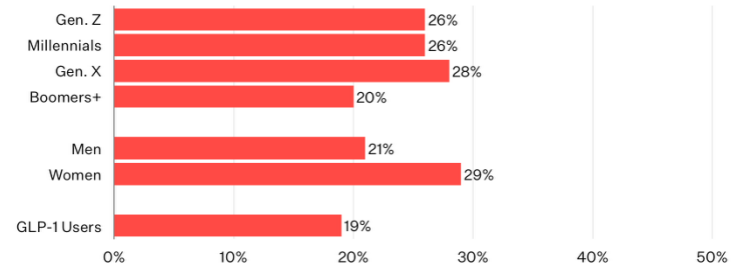


[TREND 2022-2025] G18 Which of the following best define a healthy food to you? Please select up to 5 choices (n=3000)
 Note: Arrows indicate statistical significance vs. 2024. Differences in parenthesis indicate statistical significance vs. 2022.
 Note: “Other” (0%) and “None of the above” (0%) are not shown.

PROTEIN IS TOP OF MIND FOR CONSUMERS

A quarter of Americans think they're not consuming enough protein

Percentage of 'No' responses: Do you feel like you're getting enough protein in your diet?

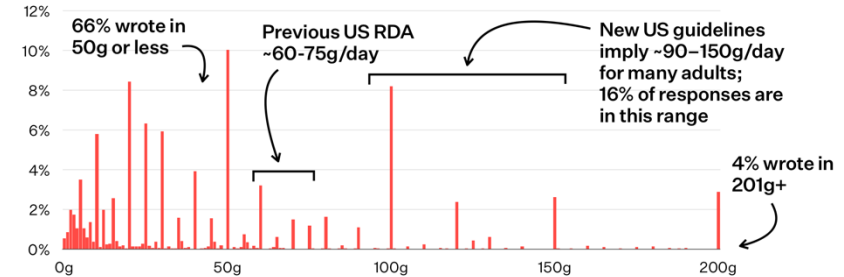


Data: The New Consumer and Coefficient Capital Consumer Trends Survey, powered by **toluna** (n=3000)

The New Consumer | Coefficient

Americans don't really know how much protein they're supposed to get

Write-in responses: About how many grams of protein per day do you think a person like you should eat?



Data: The New Consumer and Coefficient Capital Consumer Trends Survey, powered by **toluna** (n=2949)
Guidelines based on 15 LUIS + USDA Dietary Guidelines (2020, 2025 and 2025, 2020) and CDC survey weights

The New Consumer | Coefficient

BUT THEY'RE UNSURE HOW MUCH PROTEIN THEY NEED

PUTTING THE PROTEIN IN POPCORN



THE QUESTION IS:
DO CONSUMERS
WANT PROTEIN IN
THEIR POPCORN?

The Consumer Trends 2026 Protein Feelings Matrix



Data: The New Consumer and Coefficient Capital Consumer Trends Survey, powered by toluna (n=3000)
Excludes "I don't know" responses.

The New Consumer | Coefficient

BY
CONSUMERS
AND
LAWMAKERS
ALIKE

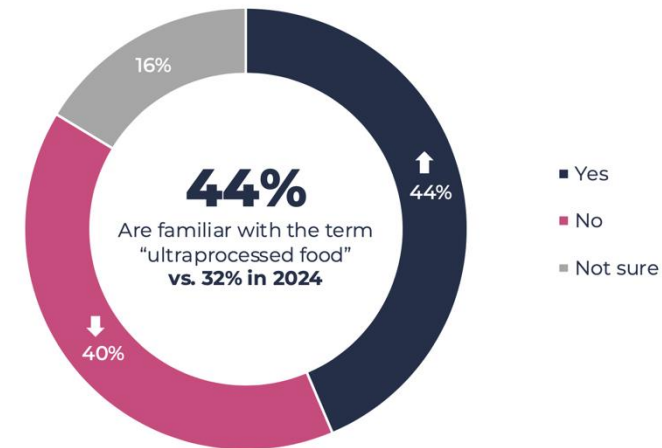
ULTRA-PROCESSED FOODS ARE UNDER ATTACK

CONSUMERS BECOMING MORE AWARE OF UPFs

In 2025, more than 4 in 10 Americans are familiar with the term “ultraprocessed food,” a 12-point jump from 2024.

Forty percent of Americans are unfamiliar with the term “ultraprocessed foods,” down from 52% in 2024. Those who are unsure remains unchanged at 16%.

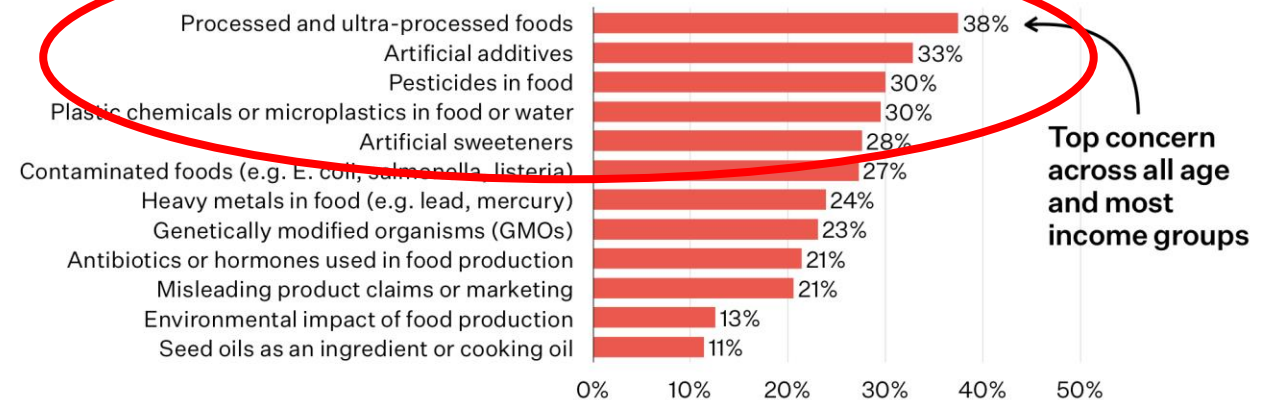
Familiarity with the Term “Ultraprocessed Food”



AND ARE
CONCERNED
ABOUT THE
INGREDIENTS
IN
PROCESSED
FOODS

US consumers' top food concerns: Processed foods and unwanted additives

Which of the following are you most concerned about
regarding the food you eat? (Choose up to five.)



Data: The New Consumer and Coefficient Capital Consumer Trends Survey, powered by **toluna** (n=3000)
Not all responses shown.

The New Consumer | Coefficient

CALL FOR MORE REGULATION



State and federal governments seeking to close GRAS “loophole”



Citizen's petition to revoke GRAS status of refined carbohydrates



State bans proposed for specific ingredients (BHA, BHT) and certain food dyes



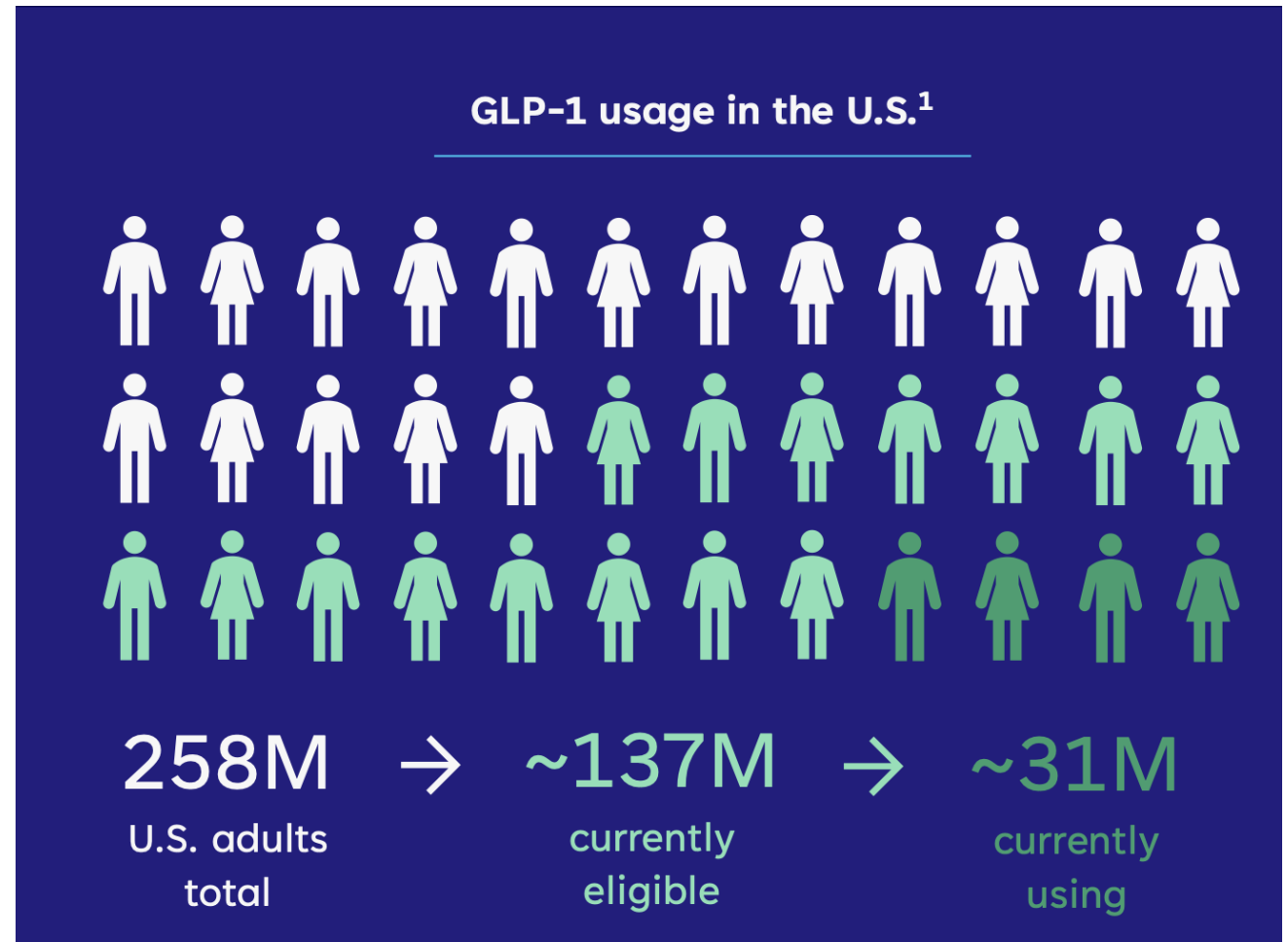
Texas, Mississippi and other states calling for warning labels and disclosures

BUT IMPACT
IS STILL
BEING
ASSESSED

GLP-1s GO
MAINSTREAM

DRUGS NOW WIDELY AVAILABLE

- Estimates range from 1 in 4 individuals to 1 in 8 have used or are using
- Circana predicts increase to 35% of homes by 2030
- Usage is expected to increase with new formats and decreased costs



THEY'RE NOT JUST FOR WEIGHT LOSS



Potential benefits for heart health, kidney disease, fertility, arthritis, and addiction.



In some cases, being viewed as longevity drugs

IMPACT ON GROCERY SALES

- HHs with at least one GLP-1 user reduce grocery spending by 5.4% (8.2% in higher in higher-income homes)
- Largest reductions in calorie-dense, processed categories, including a 10.1% decline in savory snacks
- Some categories, like yogurt, seeing positive changes
- Also increased spending on fruits (14%) and vegetables (38%)





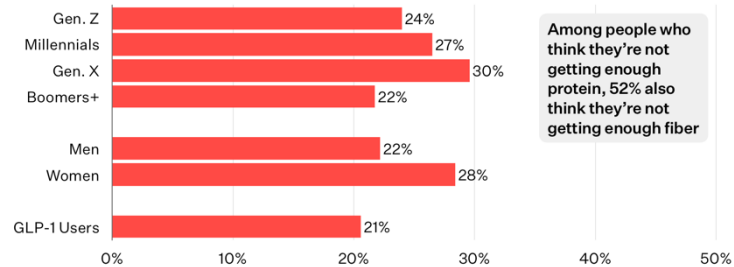
MANUFACTURERS CREATE FOODS SPECIFICALLY FOR GLP-1 USERS

SOCIAL
MEDIA
INSPIRES
CONSUMERS
TO
INCREASE
THEIR FIBER
INTAKE

FIBERMAXXING

A quarter of Americans also think they're not consuming enough fiber

Percentage of 'No' responses: Do you feel like you're getting enough fiber in your diet?

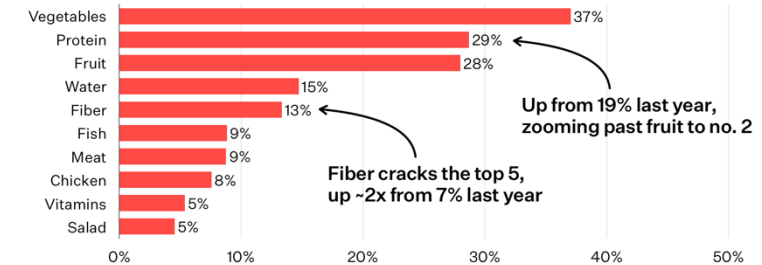


Data: The New Consumer and Coefficient Capital Consumer Trends Survey, powered by **toluna** (n=3000)

The New Consumer | Coefficient

We asked 3,000 Americans what they want to consume *more* of this year...

Percentage of respondents writing in each specific term (Submit three.)



Data: The New Consumer and Coefficient Capital Consumer Trends Survey, powered by **toluna** (n=3000)
Analyzed by Claude Opus 4.6 to combine similar words and typos.

The New Consumer | Coefficient

CONSUMERS RECOGNIZE THE NEED FOR INCREASED FIBER INTAKE

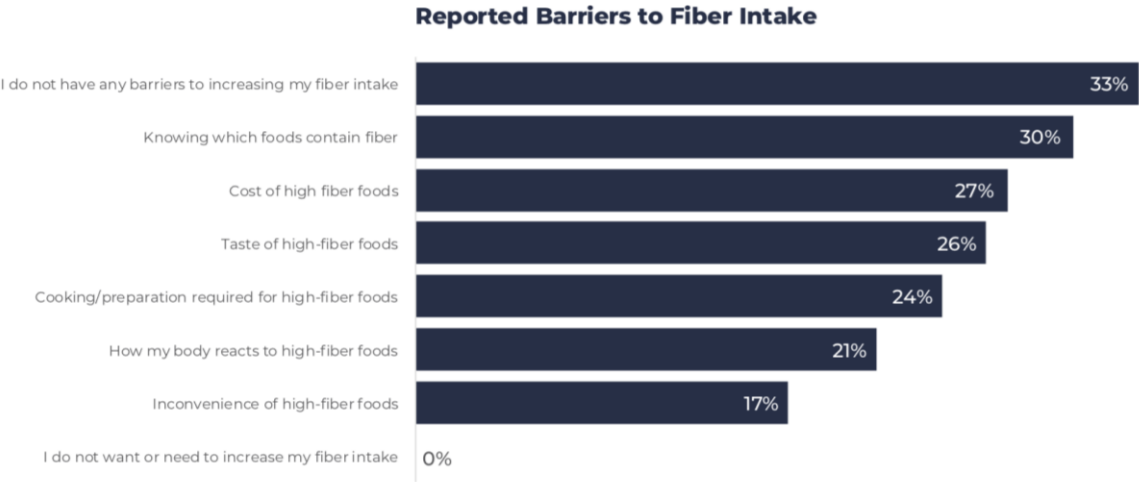
FUELED BY:

- GUT HEALTH AWARENESS
- GLP-1 & SATIETY CULTURE
- ANTI-ULTRA-PROCESSED SENTIMENT

INFLUENCERS FILL EDUCATION GAP AMONG CONSUMERS

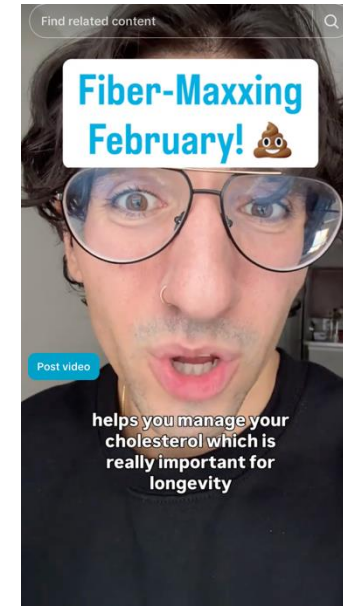
Top barriers to increasing fiber intake include knowledge, cost, and taste of high-fiber foods.

One in three (33%) report no barriers to increasing fiber intake. None indicated a lack of desire or need to increase fiber intake.



Q3. Which of the following are barriers to increasing your fiber intake? Select all that apply. (n=1006)

IFIC Spotlight Survey: Americans' Perceptions of Fiber & Whole Grains. February 2026.



ENCOURAGES PEOPLE TO
MAXIMIZE DAILY FIBER INTAKE
THROUGH WHOLE FOODS AND
FIBER-FORTIFIED PRODUCTS

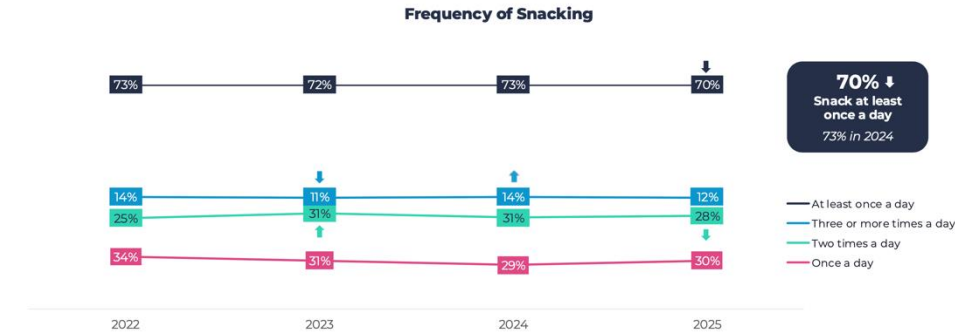
- Track grams of fiber per meal
- Showcase 30g+ fiber "day of eating"
- Swap refined carbs for whole-food, high-fiber alternatives

THE NATURE
OF
SNACKING IS
SHIFTING

SNACKING TRENDS

Seven in ten Americans snack at least once a day, down from 2024.

Since 2022, more than 70% of Americans have reported snacking at least once a day, with 40% snacking multiple times per day and 30% snacking once daily.



[TREND 2019-2025] N1 In a typical week, how often do you snack or eat something in addition to your main meals? (n=3000)

Note: 2019-2021 IFIC Food & Health Surveys did not include options for multiple snack occasions per day.

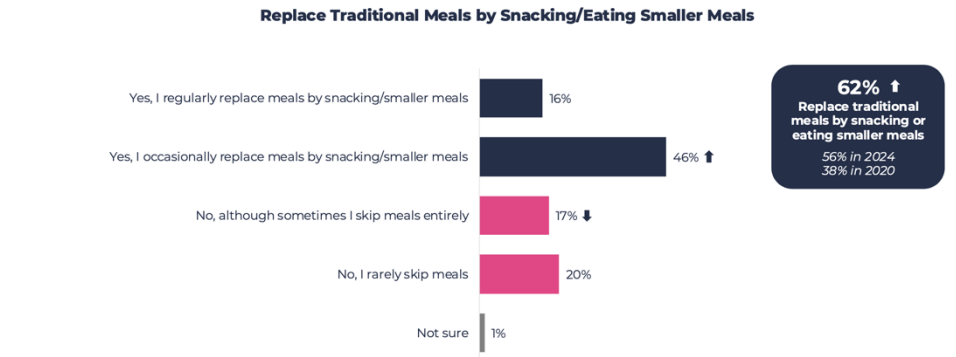
Note: Arrows in the chart indicate statistical significance vs. the previous year. Arrow in the callout box indicates statistical significance vs. years noted.

Note: "Snack at least once a day" does not add up and totals may not equal 100% due to rounding.

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Six in ten Americans report replacing traditional meals with snacks or smaller meals, a growing trend in recent years.

In 2020, 38% reported replacing traditional meals with snacks or smaller meals, rising to 56% in 2024. Meanwhile, 17% say they do not downsize meals although sometimes skip meals entirely, a significant decline from 2024.



[TREND 2020/2024-2025] N2 Do you ever replace traditional meals (breakfast, lunch, dinner) by snacking or eating smaller meals instead? (n=3000)

Note: Arrows in the chart indicate statistical significance vs. 2024. Arrow in the callout box indicates statistical significance vs. years noted.

CONSUMERS ARE SNACKING LESS AND, WHEN THEY DO SNACK, ARE USING THEM TO REPLACE MEALS

WHAT WE RE EVOLVING TOWARD

- Less mindless, indulgent
- Replaced by intentional nutrient-driven snacks
- Meals become snacks+
- Could lead to snacks with increased nutrition
- Stackable snacks – snacks that can be customized for variety, portion control, and personal nutrition needs





QUESTIONS?

THANK YOU!

- FOR MORE INFORMATION, CONTACT

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